

False Blue Indigo

Baptisia australis

Wild Blue Indigo · Blue False Indigo



QUALITIES

A long-lived herbaceous perennial of the pea family, growing 3 to 4 feet tall with the architectural presence of a small shrub. Blue-green clover-like leaves on branching upright stems form a tidy mounded clump. In late May and June, vertical racemes of indigo-blue pea-like flowers rise above the foliage, followed by inflated black seed pods that rattle decoratively into winter. The deep taproot makes Baptisia nearly impossible to transplant once established — and nearly impossible to kill.

CARE

Plant from 1-gallon container in spring, into open ground where it will live for the rest of your gardening life. Full sun, average to dry soil; tolerates drought, lean soil, and clay. Slow to establish — expect a quiet first two summers — then bullet-proof. Hardy to USDA Zone 3. As a nitrogen-fixing legume, it actively improves soil for neighboring forbs. Avoid moving once mature; if you must, do it in early spring with a tarp and prepare to lose half the root system.

HISTORY

The genus name *Baptisia* derives from Greek *baptein*, "to dye" — Indigenous peoples used several Baptisia species as a substitute for the imported indigo dye, though the color is muted compared to true *Indigofera*. Cherokee and Choctaw used a root preparation for toothache and as a purgative. In 19th-century horticulture Baptisia was promoted as a substitute for the southern lupines, since it is more cold-hardy. It has remained a stalwart of MN prairie restoration ever since.

REASON TO BE

Baptisia anchors a prairie or savanna planting in time. While neighboring forbs cycle through five-year boom-and-decline rhythms, Baptisia is in year fifteen still in the same spot, getting better. Its early-summer bloom feeds long-tongued bumblebees and the Wild Indigo Duskywing skipper, which uses Baptisia as its larval host plant. The seed pods are an ornamental feature into winter. As a nitrogen fixer, it conditions soil for the rest of the planting. Plant it as the structural backbone.